

Diacritic

A **diacritic** – also **diacritical mark**, **diacritical point**, **diacritical sign**, or **accent** – is a glyph added to a letter or basic glyph. The term derives from the Ancient Greek διακριτικός (*diakritikós*, "distinguishing"), from διακρίνω (*diakrī́ nō*, "to distinguish"). *Diacritic* is primarily an adjective, though sometimes used as a noun, whereas *diacritical* is only ever an adjective. Some diacritical marks, such as the acute (´) and grave (`), are often called *accents*. Diacritical marks may appear above or below a letter, or in some other position such as within the letter or between two letters.

The main use of diacritical marks in the Latin script is to change the sound-values of the letters to which they are added. Examples are the diaereses in the borrowed French words *naïve* and *Noël*, which show that the vowel with the diaeresis mark is pronounced separately from the preceding vowel; the acute and grave accents, which can indicate that a final vowel is to be pronounced, as in *saké* and poetic *breathèd*; and the cedilla under the "c" in the borrowed French word *façade*, which shows it is pronounced /s/ rather than /k/. In other Latin-script alphabets, they may distinguish between homonyms, such as the French *là* ("there") versus *la* ("the") that are both pronounced /la/. In Gaelic type, a dot over a consonant indicates lenition of the consonant in question.

In other alphabetic systems, diacritical marks may perform other functions. Vowel pointing systems, namely the Arabic harakat (َ , ُ , ِ , etc.) and the Hebrew niqqud (, ְ , ֶ , ֵ , ִ , ֊ , etc.) systems, indicate vowels that are not conveyed by the basic alphabet. The Indic virama (् etc.) and the Arabic sukūn (ْ) mark the absence of vowels. Cantillation marks indicate prosody. Other uses include the Early Cyrillic titlo stroke (҃) and the Hebrew gershayim ("), which, respectively, mark abbreviations or acronyms, and Greek diacritical marks, which showed that letters of the alphabet were being used as numerals. In the Hanyu Pinyin official romanization system for Chinese, diacritics are used to mark the tones of the syllables in which the marked vowels occur.

In orthography and collation, a letter modified by a diacritic may be treated either as a new, distinct letter or as a letter–diacritic combination. This varies from language to language, and may vary from case to case within a language. English is the only major modern European language requiring no diacritics for native words (although a diaeresis may be used in words such as "coöperation").^{[1][2]}

In some cases, letters are used as "in-line diacritics", with the same function as ancillary glyphs, in that they modify the sound of the letter preceding them, as in the case of the "h" in the English pronunciation of "sh" and "th".^[3]

Contents

Types

á	
Letter a with diacritic acute	
Diacritics in Latin & Greek	
accent	
acute	´
double acute	¨
grave	`
double grave	˘
circumflex	ˆ
caron, háček	ˇ
breve	˘
inverted breve	ˊ
cedilla	¸
diaeresis, umlaut	¨
dot	·
palatal hook	ˆ
retroflex hook	˚
hook above, dấu hỏi	̉
horn	̊
iota subscript	Ϳ
macron	¯
ogonek, nosiné	˛
perispomene	͂
overring	◌̊
underring	◌̋
rough breathing	◌Ϳ
smooth breathing	◌͂
Marks sometimes used as diacritics	
apostrophe	’
bar	◌̄
colon	⋮
comma	◌̣